

Q What tests will my baby have while she's in the hospital nursery?

This thorough head-to-toe checkup is given within three days of the birth, and its goal is to identify abnormalities or certain conditions that were missed during prenatal screening.

Your baby will be thoroughly examined immediately after the birth (see p.239), but will be checked again, usually by the staff pediatrician at the hospital before you are discharged. If the pediatrician that you will be seeing in private practice is making rounds at the hospital to see his or her patients, there's a chance that the doctor will see his brand-new patient before your baby leaves the hospital.

Detecting any health problems this early means that babies can be referred promptly for treatment if needed, which usually leads to better long-term outcomes.

A newborn baby's heart rate is usually around 110–160 beats per minute. To begin with, the heart is large in relation to the chest wall.

NEWBORN BABY CHECKUP

The checks below are done to confirm that your newborn baby is in good health. The pediatrician may also test your baby's reflexes again at this examination.

» **Skin:** the overall skin color and any birthmarks are observed.

» **Heart and lungs:** a stethoscope is used to make sure heart sounds and breathing patterns are normal. The pulse is checked.

» **Head and face:** the fontanelles (soft spots) on the head that allowed the bony plates to squeeze through the birth canal, are checked. Your baby's facial features are checked for symmetry.

» **Eyes:** a special light called an ophthalmoscope is used to check for "red reflex" to make sure there are no cataracts.

» **Mouth:** the roof of the mouth is examined to ensure there is no split, or cleft, in the palate.

» **Mouth:** the tongue is checked for tongue-tie, since restrictions can interfere with breast-feeding.

» **Hips:** the legs are gently bent upward and rotated at the hips, to check that hip joints are not malformed (see p.324).

» **Genitals:** in boys, the position of the testes and the penis is checked. You'll be asked if your baby has urinated and pooped.

» **Back:** the spine is examined to ensure it is properly formed.

» **Hands and feet:** the fingers and toes are examined and the creases on the palms of the hands and the resting position of the feet and ankles are checked.



Head The soft spots on your baby's head are examined. Any effects from an assisted delivery will also be checked.



Spine The spine and back are examined to ensure they are straight and free of any abnormalities.



Hips Any signs of dislocation will be found when the pediatrician rotates the baby's hips.



Hearing test This test will usually be done in hospital before you and your baby leave, or alternatively it may be done at the pediatrician's office during your baby's first week of life.

Q Why does my newborn baby need to have a hearing test in the first 24 hours after the birth?

Around 1 in 900 babies is born with some degree of hearing loss. Being aware of this early on is important for a baby's development since it means he can be given the right support and assistance and have the best chance of developing speech and language skills.

A small earpiece placed in your baby's outer ear transmits clicking sounds down the ear canal; these are received by the inner ear, which responds with an echo. It is a quick and painless procedure, which can be done while he's asleep.

Q What is vitamin K? Why does my baby need it after the birth?

Vitamin K plays an essential role in blood clotting. Some babies are born with inadequate amounts of vitamin K since it doesn't cross the placenta easily, and breast milk contains very little. This puts them at risk of a rare, but potentially fatal, condition—vitamin K deficiency bleeding of the newborn (VKDB), where bleeding can occur in the nose, mouth, and sometimes in the brain. The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends that every newborn baby receive a single vitamin K intramuscular injection, especially for those that are breast-fed.